

SYLLABUS

LING 530F
Linguistic Problems
in a Special Area

NATURAL LANGUAGE ONTOLOGY:
WHAT MODELS ARE MADE OF

1 Course information

This course is graduate seminar on the grammar of natural language ontology. It's scheduled for Mondays 2:00–5:00 in the Totem Field Studios seminar room.

2 Prerequisites

LING 425/525 or the equivalent. We'll assume the essential tools of formal semantics. This includes lambda abstraction, predicate logic, semantic types, and a type-driven theory of the syntax-semantics interface.

That said, because that's quite a lot and because this is a small class, we can take the time to fill in additional background as needed.

3 Contact information

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Office hours: 2:00–3:00 Wednesdays or by appointment on [Zoom](#), or, by prior arrangement, in person
Office: Totem Field Studios 226
Canvas: We'll use Canvas for communication and logistical support.

4 Outcomes

- Engage with ideas about the building blocks of models in natural language semantics. Provide some answers to the question of what languages tell us about (cognitive representations of) the world.
- Discuss these issues with colleagues in an original and ideally entertaining way, developing ideas collaboratively.
- Push beyond existing work to make an independent contribution to research in a way that's broadly relevant to the theme.
- Channel this into a paper that could in principle be published (as a conference proceedings paper, in a journal, etc.).

5 Course structure

The topic of the seminar is the natural language ontology. We'll read and discuss literature relevant literature and present both others' work and our own to each other. Participants will also write an original research paper more or less related to the issues discussed in class.

6 Activities

The requirements for this course are:

- Participating *vigorously* in the discussion. This is not syllabus window-dressing. It is really a requirement. It's the best way I know to make this fun and truly a collaborative enterprise.
- Writing an original research paper (or a squib, i.e. short paper, if appropriate; we can discuss what this means later).
- Presenting your work on that paper.
- Presenting one of the readings.

7 Assessment

Final grades will be determined on the basis of written work and your contributions in class (in class presentations and more generally).

Overall participation:	25%
Presentation of an existing paper:	15%
Original research paper presentation:	15%
Original research paper write-up:	45%

8 Notes and course policies

Communication and work format You'll receive materials via Canvas, and that's also where you'll turn in your work. Make all work a PDF file. Please *don't* submit files in Word or any other format.

Disability Please notify me during the first two weeks of the course to make any special arrangements to accommodate a disability. If you haven't already done so, you should contact the UBC Centre for Accessibility.

Academic integrity Don't plagiarize. The structure of the course may make this a little trickier than it might seem. If someone that isn't actually a coauthor gives you an idea that you use or build on, explicitly acknowledge this in the text. Explicit discussion of citation practices is occasionally helpful, so please don't hesitate to ask questions. For more on the university's academic integrity policies, look at the university's Academic Honesty and Standards statement.

Social media and copyright issues Don't share course materials (hand-outs, assignments, recordings, etc.) with anyone outside of class. Don't record anything that happens in class without my prior approval.

9 University policies

Here is the standard UBC syllabus text about university policies and support:

UBC provides resources to support student learning and to maintain healthy lifestyles but recognizes that sometimes crises arise and so there are additional resources to access including those for survivors of sexual violence. UBC values respect for the person and ideas of all members of the academic community. Harassment and discrimination are not tolerated nor is suppression of academic freedom. UBC provides appropriate accommodation for students with disabilities and for religious observances. UBC values academic honesty and students are expected to acknowledge the ideas generated by others and to uphold the highest academic standards in all of their actions.

Details of the policies and how to access support are available on the [UBC Senate website](#).

10 Acknowledgment

Here is the land acknowledgment we've officially adopted as a department:

We acknowledge that the University of British Columbia is located on the traditional, ancestral and unceded territories of the

x^wmə^ʔ0k^wəyəm, Skwxwú7mesh, and Səlílwətał Nations (Vancouver campuses) and the Syilx peoples (Okanagan campus). We at UBC Linguistics consider this land acknowledgment to be an opportunity to show our commitment towards reconciliation and the recognition of Indigenous peoples and languages. Please visit native-land.ca or maps.fpcc.ca to learn more about these places, peoples and languages.

There's a corresponding intellectual fact worth acknowledging: that much of what linguistics has achieved rests on the empirical foundation of data shared with us by countless native-speaker consultants over multiple generations, not infrequently in difficult circumstances.

11 Tentative schedule

This will be modified and adjusted over the course of the semester to accommodate the direction of our conversation, our collective interests, and the pace at which we proceed. This schedule is ambitious. We'll probably go at a slower pace than indicated here. I'll provide updates.

Jan. 5	syllabus & logistics introductory chatting a brief big-picture preliminary spiel
Jan. 12	events: Davidson (1967) , Parsons (1990, chap. 2, 3, 5)
Jan. 19	states: Maienborn (2007) analogies across domains: events, states, times, mass, count: Bach (1986)
Jan. 26	degrees: Kennedy (1997, chap. 1) ontological questions about degrees: Kennedy (2001)
Feb. 2	tropes as degrees/degrees as tropes: Moltmann (2009) degrees and nominalizations: Bochnak et al. (2025)
Feb. 9	kinds (and mass/count distinction again): Chierchia (1998) ¹ degrees as kinds: Anderson & Morzycki (2015)
Feb. 16	<i>Reading week, which ironically means we're not reading anything.</i>
Feb. 23	property concepts and qualities: Francez & Koontz-Garboden (2015) individuals & content: Moulton (2009, ch. 1–2)
March 2	locative expressions and the ontology of space: Zwarts (1997) and/or Zwarts (2017) ranges and spatial notions in non-spatial domains: Gobeski & Morzycki (2024)

¹The classic reference (apart from the Chierchia) is [Carlson \(1977\)](#).

March 9	why questions and reasons, causes, purposes: Cox (2021) and Egler (2021) ²
March 16	‘super semantics’ and the structure of pictures: Maier (2019) utterances as objects in the model: Potts (2007)
March 23	<i>Paper presentations</i>
March 30	<i>Paper presentations</i>
April 6	<i>Easter. No class.</i>

Alternatives A few possible additions/replacements/alternatives, in addition to ones I’ve mentioned in footnotes:

- Computational linguists worry extensively about ontologies and sortal distinctions within domains, and this features in a certain sort of work on lexical semantics. This might be worth pursuing further. A starting point is [Pustejovsky \(1995\)](#), though we’d have to narrow that down for it to be tractable, and perhaps something shorter and more recent is preferable in any case.
- I’m slightly sad about not having scheduled a time to talk specifically about whether there is such a thing as ‘manners’, but it might come up as a side effect of the discussion on degrees as kinds. Potential stuff to read would be [Katz \(2008\)](#), my own recent squib on manners ([Morzycki 2024](#)), or [Gehrke \(2019\)](#) on event-kinds generally. The idea is explored in detail in [Alexeyenko \(2015\)](#).³
- A number of us in the department are interested in numerals, the ontology of which is itself interesting. There was a special issue of *Linguistics & Philosophy* on this topic. Potential reading: [Snyder \(2017\)](#), or portions of [Scontras \(2014\)](#).

Everyone should feel free to make suggestions, early on or as we proceed.

References

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- Anderson, Curt & Marcin Morzycki. 2015. ‘Degrees as kinds’. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 33(3), 791–828.

²Potential supplemental readings: [Skow \(2016\)](#) is a book-length discussion of ‘why’, reasons, and causes; [Kay & Fillmore \(1999\)](#) has discussion of non-canonical questions that involve ‘why’-like interpretations of *what*

³I definitely don’t want to collectively read [Landman & Morzycki \(2003\)](#), though its one early place where manners as objects in the ontology come up.

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- Maienborn, Claudia. 2007. 'On Davidsonian and Kimian states'. In Ileana Comorovski & Klaus von Heusinger (eds.), *Existence: Semantics and Syntax*, pp. 107–130. Springer, Dordrecht.

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